

got for the other car was \$4,000 less. I was about to pay \$4,000 for adaptive cruise control and leather seats . . . because I was tired. I thought, if I wanted it that bad, I could get it installed for less than that. And I don't even care about leather. Walking away from that showroom was physically painful. All that time and effort was spent for nothing. But we immediately picked up my son, went to the other dealership where the price they showed online was the price they charged, and got the van with less mileage for \$4,000 less than I was about to pay. I negotiated to the best of my ability, but what saved me the most money was that I was willing to say no when the negotiations were not going in my favor.

One decision saved me \$4,000. So much of the conversation on saving money is centered around how many things you can do to save money. The more things you do, the more you save, right? In reality, there are a thousand \$4 decisions I no longer have to worry about simply because I was intentional with this one. That's why when we think about spending on needs, we take a less is more approach. How can we save as much as possible by doing as little as possible?

The Vital Few and the Useful Many

In 1906, economist Vilfredo Pareto noticed that 80 percent of Italy's land was owned by roughly 20 percent of the population. He then researched land ownership in a variety of other countries and found, to his surprise, a similar distribution in each. In 1941, engineer Joseph Juran came across Pareto's work and found it applied to quality issues. He found that once you find the 20 percent of causes that make up the majority of your quality issues, you can save a lot of time and effort by always trying those first. Most people call it the ^{80/20} rule, but Juran referred to it as "the vital few and the useful many," to remind us that while we should start with the most important 20 percent, the remaining 80 percent of causes shouldn't be ignored. We found that most of the frugal living content out there focused on the "useful many," rebate apps, coupons, deals, etc. And while all those things are useful, we want to start with the vital few. Instead of stressing yourself out with a hundred things you need to do to save \$4 here and \$50 there, start with the few actions that can save you the most money, then incorporate the "useful many" at a rate that feels good to you.